PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

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Lecture 1: What does comparison explain?

Comparative politics is both a **subject** and a **method**.

By the end of today, you should be able to:

1. distinguish comparative politics from country description;
2. explain the **many variables, few cases** problem;
3. recognize most-similar and most-different designs; and
4. connect the field's history to our constitutional-engineering project.

Start with a comparison

Taiwan

- Semi-presidential system
- Mixed electoral rules
- Competitive democracy

South Korea

- Presidential system
- Mixed electoral rules
- Competitive democracy

What could this pairing help us explain—and what could it **not** establish by itself?

The book begins with a problem

Ishiyama does not organize the course as a tour of countries.

He organizes it around a practical question:

Under what conditions can political democracy develop—and when will institutional engineering fail?

- Theories become useful when applied to a consequential problem.
- Institutional choices must fit historical, economic, social, cultural, and international conditions.
- Democracy is not assumed to be easy, inevitable, or universally transplantable.

A problem-based course

Problem → diagnose a focal country's political constraints

Comparison → use a shadow case to test explanations

Design → evaluate institutional alternatives and trade-offs

Defense → explain why the recommendation fits the evidence

> The goal is not to discover a perfect constitution. It is to make a **defensible comparative claim**.

Defining comparative politics

Three definitions compete

1. The study of **foreign countries**
2. The study of **comparative government**
3. A **subject and method** of political inquiry

> Ishiyama adopts the third definition: systematic comparison of political phenomena **within political systems**.

The United States is therefore one case among many—not a separate universe.

Subject and method work together

As a subject

Political phenomena **within** a state, society, country, or political system:

- institutions;
- behavior; and
- political ideas.

As a method

Systematic comparison used to:

- identify similarities and differences;
- discover patterns; and
- explain variation.

Comparative politics asks "why?"

Description

How does a legislature work?

Who selects the executive?

What electoral formula is used?

Explanation

Why did this institution emerge?

Why does it produce different outcomes elsewhere?

Under what conditions will it change?

Description supplies evidence. Comparison turns evidence into an explanation.

Within states—or between them?

Comparative politics	International relations
Politics primarily **within** political systems	Politics primarily **between** political systems
Elections, parties, courts, executives, identity, participation	War, alliances, trade, diplomacy, international organizations
Why outcomes vary across cases	Why states and other actors interact as they do

The boundary is useful, but not absolute: international forces also shape domestic politics.

The comparative method

The central constraint

Imagine explaining the Russian Revolution with one case.

- Military defeat and wartime strain?
- Economic and social transformation?
- Bolshevik organization and Lenin's leadership?
- Paralysis at the top of the imperial regime?

Many plausible causes + one observed outcome = weak causal leverage.

Lijphart's formulation: comparative politics often has **too many variables and too few cases**.

Three strategies for causal leverage

Strategy	How it controls alternatives	Main constraint
Experiment	Randomization and a control group	Countries cannot usually be assigned to treatments
Statistical method	Estimates several relationships at once	Requires enough cases and defensible measures
Comparative method	Selects cases to hold key factors constant	Conclusions depend heavily on case-selection logic

The comparative method is a **quasi-experimental** strategy for a small number of cases.

Most-Similar Systems Design

Compare cases that are similar on relevant background conditions but differ on the outcome or institution of interest.

Similar cases + different outcome → investigate the remaining difference.

This is Mill's **Method of Difference**.

- Strength: controls many rival explanations through case selection.
- Risk: the cases may differ in an unnoticed but consequential way.

Estonia and Latvia illustrate MSSD

Both cases shared important conditions before the Soviet collapse:

- annexation in 1940;
- indigenous and Russophone populations;
- relatively high Soviet-era development;
- unitary, roughly parliamentary systems.

Key difference	Latvia	Estonia
1989–90 electoral rule	Single-member plurality	Single Transferable Vote

Different party-system development could then be investigated through the electoral-rule difference.

Cold call: defend a pairing

Return to **Taiwan and South Korea**.

1. What important conditions does the pairing approximately hold constant?
2. What institutional or political difference could provide leverage?
3. What unmeasured difference could undermine the comparison?

A defensible comparison identifies both its **leverage** and its **limits**.

Most-Different Systems Design

Compare cases that differ widely but share the same outcome.

Different cases + same outcome → search for a common cause.

This is Mill's **Method of Similarity**.

- Strength: a shared factor may travel across diverse contexts.
- Risk: different causal paths can generate the same outcome.

Design check

Scenario A

Two economically and culturally similar democracies adopt different electoral systems and develop different party systems.

Scenario B

Three societies with different histories, economies, and institutions all experience democratic breakdown after elected leaders disable checks and balances.

Which is **MSSD**? Which is **MDSD**? What would each comparison need to measure?

How the field evolved

Two tensions organize the history

Normative ↔ empirical

Should scholars ask what political order **ought** to be—or explain what can be observed?

Understanding ↔ application

Is the purpose to build general knowledge—or improve political institutions?

Comparative politics repeatedly moves between these poles rather than permanently choosing one side.

Plato and Aristotle offer two traditions

Plato

- Knowledge through reason and insight
- Emphasis on justice and the ideal order
- Foundation of a **normative** tradition

Aristotle

- Approximately 150 constitutions as evidence
- Comparison of institutions and social foundations
- Foundation of an **empirical** tradition

Both nevertheless asked how political life might be improved.

Aristotle classified regimes

Rule by	Public-serving form	Self-serving form
One	Monarchy	Tyranny
Few	Aristocracy	Oligarchy
Many	Polity	Democracy

For Aristotle, "democracy" meant corrupt rule by the many—not the modern idea of constitutional democracy.

His larger claim: mixed government supported by a strong middle class was more stable than pure oligarchy or pure democracy.

Comparison revived with a changing world

- Exploration exposed Europeans to political systems beyond Europe.
- Modern states developed distinct institutions, economies, and political cultures.
- Renaissance science restored confidence in observation and systematic inquiry.

Machiavelli

Compared political practices to find models that rulers could emulate.

Montesquieu

Compared political systems and advanced separation of powers—but also made dubious climate-based claims.

Marx and Weber disagree about causation

Marx

Economic relations and class power shape political and social institutions.

Primary causal emphasis: political economy

Weber

Culture, religion, institutions, and political leadership have partly autonomous effects.

Primary causal emphasis: multicausal explanation

Cold call: What evidence would distinguish these explanations?

The American field started descriptively

Early twentieth-century American comparative politics largely emphasized:

- European governments;
- formal and legal institutions; and
- description of legislatures, executives, and courts.

World War II and the Cold War increased demand for knowledge about:

- rebuilding Germany and Japan;
- Soviet and communist politics;
- decolonization and political instability; and
- democratic development.

Macridis demanded explanation

The "traditional approach" was criticized as:

1. **parochial**—centered on Europe;
2. **descriptive**—missing the why question;
3. **monographic**—focused narrowly on formal institutions;
4. **not genuinely comparative**—countries appeared in separate silos; and
5. **static**—unable to explain political change.

This critique helped shift the field from describing governments to explaining political behavior and change.

Categories can distort what we observe

Ishiyama recounts an example from precolonial West Africa:

- some communities selected "kings" by rotation among notable families;
- British officials interpreted kingship as hereditary;
- indirect rule converted a rotating office into a life appointment inherited by heirs.

> Using a familiar European label obscured the institution—and colonial policy then changed it.

Comparison requires concepts that travel without erasing local meaning.

The behavioral revolution changed the unit of analysis

Behavioralists emphasized:

- theory joined to empirical observation;
- surveys, content analysis, statistics, history, and qualitative evidence;
- insights from economics, sociology, and psychology;
- common concepts such as power, political system, and democracy; and
- an aspiration toward value-free science.

The field moved beyond constitutions on paper to study what political actors actually **do**.

Easton put politics inside an environment

Environment supplies demands and support

↓

Political system converts inputs into authoritative decisions

↓

Outputs reshape society and the international environment

↺ **Feedback** creates new demands and support

The system includes government, parties, interest groups, and leaders—not only formal institutions.

Easton's "black box" remains a problem

The systems model clarifies interdependence, but it leaves major questions open:

- What actually happens inside the conversion process?
- Why do political systems process similar demands differently?
- Can the model explain democratic collapse or institutional change?
- Does naming a system's components produce a testable explanation?

A framework organizes observation; a theory must also specify causal expectations.

Structural functionalism looks beneath labels

Almond and Coleman asked two separate questions:

1. What **structures** exist?
2. What political **functions** must be performed?

The same function can be performed by different structures:

- parties may aggregate interests in one system;
- the military, a ruling party, or patronage networks may do so elsewhere;
- courts, bureaucracies, or party organs may regulate and adjudicate.

Political systems must perform recurring functions

Process functions

- Interest articulation
- Interest aggregation
- Policy making
- Regulation
- Adjudication

System-maintenance functions

- Political socialization
- Recruitment of leaders
- Political communication

Cold call: Which structures perform these functions in China? In Taiwan?

Structural functionalism also has limits

- It assumes system survival is the central goal.
- It can portray political systems as static rather than adaptive.
- Its categories may reflect Western democratic experience.
- It says little about how institutions emerged or changed.

The field escaped narrow formalism, but risked replacing it with abstract concepts that explained too little.

Post-behavioralism reopened purpose

Critics challenged two behavioralist commitments:

1. **Value-free science:** political facts require interpretation, and interpretation cannot be fully separated from values.
2. **Method over substance:** technical refinement can displace consequential political questions.

Post-behavioral and constructivist approaches emphasized how political realities and categories are socially constructed.

Neo-institutionalism brought rules back in

Behavioralism looked beyond formal rules; neo-institutionalism asked what had been lost.

- Electoral systems shape representation and party competition.
- Executive design shapes coordination and deadlock.
- Federal arrangements distribute authority and conflict.
- Courts and constitutions structure enforcement and restraint.

Institutions matter because people can redesign rules more readily than they can redesign history, culture, or economic structure.

The field comes full circle

Ancient question: What political arrangement supports a good and stable order?

Behavioral correction: Explain politics empirically, beyond formal rules.

Neo-institutional synthesis: Use comparative evidence to understand how rules shape outcomes in context.

> Comparative politics becomes applicable again—but with greater methodological discipline.

Context before design

Ishiyama organizes the book in two stages:

The political "soil"

- Historical development
- Economy
- Political culture and identity
- Social structure
- International environment

Institutional choices

- Electoral system
- Executive and legislature
- Courts
- Federalism and local authority
- Interactions among the rules

Design cannot compensate automatically for hostile contextual conditions.

Your team's comparative logic

Every team should eventually complete this sentence:

> Because our focal country and shadow comparator are similar on **[background conditions]** but differ on **[key factor or outcome]**, their comparison helps us evaluate the claim that **[cause]** conditions **[outcome]**.

Then add:

> The comparison cannot rule out **[rival explanation]**, so we will seek additional evidence from **[source or case]**.

Five ideas to carry forward

1. Comparative politics is a **subject and method**.
2. Its central challenge is **many explanations, few cases**.
3. MSSD and MDSD create leverage through **case selection**.
4. The field repeatedly negotiates **values, evidence, and application**.
5. Institutional design works only when evaluated **in context**.

The standard for this course: make a clear claim, show comparative evidence, and state the limits of the inference.

Exit question

What makes a comparison **persuasive** rather than merely interesting?

Submit three sentences:

1. one claim about a political outcome;
2. one case pairing that could evaluate it; and
3. one rival explanation the pairing cannot eliminate.

Chapter source

Ishiyama, John T. 2012. *Comparative Politics: Principles of Democracy and Democratization*. Wiley-Blackwell. Introduction: "Comparative Politics and Democracy."